AWAN

CHARACTERS

AYAN
Seventeen. The granddaughter. She dresses in an androgynous style and likes a girl. Smart, sharp-tongued, and sensitive underneath.

GRANDMOTHER
A traditional Guangdong woman. She believes in ancestors, rules, worshipping Tai Sui, and beating the petty person. She controls Ayan, but her control comes from fear and a lifetime of endurance. She knows Awan's story, but has never wanted to tell it.

MOTHER'S VOICE
Ayan's mother. She appears through a phone call.

OLD IMMORTAL
A comic figure whom Grandmother invites to "cure" Ayan.

AWAN / THE AUNTIE'S PHOTO
A projected photograph of a late-Qing or Republican-era Guangdong self-combed woman. She does not speak. She wears a loose dajin blouse and wide trousers, her hair combed up, sitting very straight. Beneath the photograph, there is no full name, only:

Auntie of the Chen Family

STAGE

The foreground is Grandmother's living room in Guangdong: rosewood chairs, a tea table, an electric fan, a household altar, an incense burner, a fruit plate, an old almanac, red strings, red socks, amulets, paper figures, slippers, a folded dress, and an open suitcase.

The upstage projection shows a Guangdong ancestral hall: grey brick walls, wooden beams, ancestral tablets, a genealogy book, and incense smoke.

At the center of the ancestral hall projection is an old photograph: a Guangdong self-combed woman from the late Qing or Republican era. Her hair is combed up; she wears a dark dajin blouse and wide trousers; her expression is calm. She does not look like a bride, or a mother, or the usual "Mrs. So-and-so" seen in ancestral halls. She sits there alone.

Beneath the photograph is written:

Auntie of the Chen Family

Cicadas can be heard outside the window. They are faint at the beginning and grow louder toward the end.

TEXT

Lights up.

At the beginning, Grandmother is preparing offerings for worship.

GRANDMOTHER Ayan, it's time to worship the ancestors.

Ayan is wearing a very oversized pair of shorts.

GRANDMOTHER What are you doing! Go out! How can you worship the ancestors dressed like that? Hurry up and change.
AYAN I don't have any other clothes. They're all like this.
GRANDMOTHER Hurry up and put on this qipao.

Ayan holds the qipao and looks at it.

AYAN This—how am I supposed to wear this?
This is such a stereotype.
I don't want to wear clothes like this.
GRANDMOTHER What stereotype?
These are the rules. Put it on.

She changes and comes out awkwardly.

Afternoon. Guangdong. Grandmother's home.

Ayan crouches on the floor, packing her suitcase. She wears a loose shirt and trousers. On her wrist are two red strings: an old one from her girlfriend, and a new one Grandmother forced onto her during these ten days.

Grandmother sits by the table peeling lychees. On the table are red socks, red underwear, amulets, an old almanac, paper figures, and slippers. The skirt Grandmother wanted Ayan to wear is folded over the back of a chair.

The fan turns.

The cicadas are faint.

Ayan takes a pair of red socks out of the suitcase and places them on the table.

AYAN I'm not taking this.

Grandmother glances at them.

GRANDMOTHER They're new.
AYAN I know.
But I don't need ten pairs of red socks.
GRANDMOTHER When you offend Tai Sui, you have to wear red.
AYAN Grandma, I've told you many times. I haven't offended Tai Sui.

Grandmother peels lychees.

GRANDMOTHER Just because you say you haven't, you haven't? You get to decide?

Ayan picks up the old almanac on the table.

AYAN Then who gets to decide? This book?
Can it calculate what time I'm going to shit tomorrow too?
GRANDMOTHER Girls shouldn't speak so crudely.
AYAN There you go again.
Look at this. Red socks. This, an amulet. This, the Old Immortal's WeChat payment code. This, the paper figure for beating the petty person.

She picks up the paper figure.

Four characters are written on the paper figure:

Not Like a Girl

Ayan looks at the paper figure.

AYAN I still haven't figured it out.
Are you trying to beat the petty person, or are you trying to beat me?
GRANDMOTHER I told you. I'm not beating you.
AYAN Then why does the paper figure have me written on it?
GRANDMOTHER I didn't write your name.
AYAN "Not Like a Girl" is more accurate than my name.

Grandmother falls silent.

Ayan puts the paper figure back on the table.

AYAN Do you know what? These ten days at your house have been incredibly fulfilling.
Day one, entering the ancestral hall.
Day two, wearing red.
Day three, video consultation.
Day four, Buddhist chants.
Day five, beating the petty person.
Day six, copying family rules.
Day seven, drawing a fortune stick.
Day eight, you went through my luggage.
Day nine, you made me wear a skirt to meet relatives.
Day ten, I'm finally being discharged.
GRANDMOTHER Discharged from what hospital?
AYAN The Traditional Female Correction Center.

Grandmother angrily throws the lychee peel into the bowl.

GRANDMOTHER Pah, pah, pah. That mouth of yours really needs to be taken to be blessed.

AYAN Haven't you already done that?
The Old Immortal said my "eyes are very hard."

Grandmother picks up her phone.

GRANDMOTHER The master has a point.
You look at people too directly, like you're about to start a fight.
AYAN I'm nearsighted.
GRANDMOTHER It wasn't easy for me to invite the Old Immortal here again. Speak properly later. Don't drive her away.

A knock at the door.

GRANDMOTHER Come in, come in, please sit down.

Grandmother drags Ayan in front of the Old Immortal.

OLD IMMORTAL Not as straight anymore.
AYAN Huh? You can see that?
GRANDMOTHER Of course. This is a master. If the master says you're not straight, then you're not straight.
AYAN I...
OLD IMMORTAL Your gaze is not so direct anymore...
Let me adjust you again today. This young girl... her vital energy is unsettled... yin and yang are out of balance... if there is a female ancestor's photograph at home... let her recognize her proper place before the ancestors...
GRANDMOTHER Good, good, good.

[Project the photograph.] [Let it appear briefly as a metaphor.]

OLD IMMORTAL If it still doesn't work, if the effect still isn't good... we can add another round of beating the petty person... I'll take the trouble. As for the donation, WeChat is fine, Alipay is fine, bank transfer is also fine, 7326...

Ayan looks at Grandmother and interrupts.

AYAN Grandma! Have you ever thought that this damned fraud just wants your money?

[The master is driven out.]

GRANDMOTHER Ah, Master, Master!
Ayan, what nonsense are you saying?
You're just a little girl.
Pah, pah, pah. Don't blaspheme the spirits. The master's words are very effective!
AYAN Grandma.
AYAN I don't understand.
I don't understand why liking someone becomes "yin and yang out of balance."
And I don't understand why every one of you thinks I'm a strange person.

A brief pause.

The cicadas grow slightly louder.

GRANDMOTHER No one said you were strange.
AYAN But every one of you points fingers at me. I can't breathe here at all.

Grandmother says nothing.

Ayan looks at the dress.

AYAN I'm not taking this qipao either.
GRANDMOTHER This qipao is not for you to take away.
AYAN Then who is it for?
GRANDMOTHER For you to wear tonight.
Your mother will be back soon, and relatives might come too.
Dress properly.

Ayan looks at Grandmother.

AYAN Do I not look proper now?

GRANDMOTHER No.
AYAN How?

Grandmother opens her mouth but cannot answer.

AYAN I just don't look like the version you imagined, right? Grandma, I am myself, a unique me. Stop judging me all the time.
GRANDMOTHER What chicken? Fried chicken or white-cut chicken, I don't care.
GRANDMOTHER Girls should look like girls.

Ayan suddenly laughs, a little speechless.

AYAN Again with "girls should look like girls."
AYAN How many times have I heard that sentence these ten days?
Girls should wear skirts.
Girls should worship the ancestors.
Girls shouldn't talk back.
Girls shouldn't run around.
Girls shouldn't like girls.
Then what exactly are girls allowed to do?
AYAN Embroider? Copy family rules? Bind their feet?

Grandmother says coldly.

GRANDMOTHER Women have always been like this. This is life.

Ayan goes quiet.

This sentence is not an argument; it is the answer Grandmother truly believes.

Ayan looks at her.

AYAN Do you like your life?

Grandmother does not answer.

Ayan looks at the photograph of the auntie upstage.

In the photograph, the woman's hair is combed up and she wears loose clothing. She has no husband and no children; she has left only a photograph in a corner of the ancestral hall.

AYAN Who is she?
GRANDMOTHER Your auntie.
AYAN Auntie? What does that mean? Your older sister? Your younger sister? Why is she here?
GRANDMOTHER Have some lychees.
AYAN I asked you on the first day.
What is her name?
GRANDMOTHER Everyone in the family calls her Auntie.
AYAN Auntie isn't a name either.
AYAN Doesn't she deserve a name? Why is she so mysterious?

Grandmother eats a lychee.

GRANDMOTHER A woman's name follows her father when she is young, and her husband after marriage. That is the rule.

Ayan walks closer to the photograph.

AYAN But she doesn't look like the other ancestors.
Others are photographed as couples, or have "wife of so-and-so" written behind them.
Why is she sitting alone?
AYAN Why have I never seen her in the ancestral hall? She is really mysterious.

Grandmother does not answer.

Ayan looks at the words beneath the photograph.

AYAN Auntie of the Chen Family.
Grandma, she never married?

Grandmother looks up at her, then quickly lowers her head again.

GRANDMOTHER In the old days, in the Pearl River Delta region of Guangdong, some women did not marry.
They would comb up their own hair, and that meant they would not marry for life.
AYAN Comb up their own hair? What does that mean?
GRANDMOTHER Mm.

A documentary about self-combed women.

A piece of history is uncovered.

Planting a clue.

With historical evidence.

AYAN Oh, Grandma. So it wasn't that nobody wanted her.
She chose not to marry.

Grandmother does not answer immediately.

It feels like a memory addressed to the audience.

GRANDMOTHER Don't speak of it so lightly.
For women back then, not marrying was not as free as you imagine.
Their families disliked it, clan elders disliked it; after death it was hard for them to enter the ancestral grave or the ancestral hall.
Some self-combed women had to live in auntie houses, and some had to depend on sisters to get through life.

PPT: black background, white text. What is an Auntie House?

Ayan walks closer to the photograph again. Her voice softens.

Ayan walks into the image. Two cultures collide. She steps into the projection, into this picture.

AYAN Sisters?

Grandmother realizes she has said too much and immediately stops herself.

GRANDMOTHER Just sisters who worked together.
In places like Shunde and Nanhai, many women used to work in silk-reeling factories. Once they had some money in their hands, their hearts grew hard.

Ayan looks at Grandmother.

AYAN Hard?
GRANDMOTHER A hard heart means a woman has confidence and no longer needs to stretch out her hand and ask a man for money.
GRANDMOTHER Too hard, and it breaks.
AYAN But if the heart is too soft, it gets molded into whatever shape other people want.
AYAN Grandma, just like you and Grandpa.

Grandmother says nothing.

Ayan looks back at the photograph.

AYAN Grandma, didn't you say women have to marry and have children to be on the right path?
AYAN Then what are they?
GRANDMOTHER I don't care about other people. You must be normal.
AYAN Grandma, were they lesbians? Did they also like women?

Grandmother looks at her sharply.

GRANDMOTHER Don't talk nonsense! What "lesbian," what "lace edge," what four edges?
AYAN Grandma, you reacted so strongly.
AYAN That means it wasn't impossible.
GRANDMOTHER That was not how people said it back then.
AYAN Then how did they say it back then?
AYAN Grandma, tell me.

Grandmother is silent for a long time.

GRANDMOTHER A vowed intimate bond.

For the first time, Ayan does not immediately talk back.

AYAN Then what was her person called?
GRANDMOTHER Who?
AYAN Her vowed intimate.

Grandmother avoids her eyes.

GRANDMOTHER I don't know.
AYAN You know.

The lychee in Grandmother's hand is crushed; juice runs down her fingers.

GRANDMOTHER Her name was Axin. Axin and Awan. Vowed intimates.

Silence.

The cicadas grow a little louder.

Ayan looks at the photograph.

AYAN Awan?

Grandmother immediately says:

GRANDMOTHER I didn't say her name was Awan.

Ayan looks at her.

AYAN You slipped just now. And you said "intimate."

Grandmother says nothing more.

Ayan slowly smiles, but not mockingly.

AYAN So our family used to have a woman who never married.
She had her own sisters, her own name, her own path.
But you all hang her here and only write "Auntie of the Chen Family" beneath her.
AYAN Why doesn't she deserve her own name? Awan is such a beautiful name.

Grandmother suddenly stands.

GRANDMOTHER Enough! Stop talking! Don't think that just because you've read a few books, you can understand women like us! (Life) is not as simple as you say.

Alienation: Ayan speaks to the audience: This is the first time in all these days that I have heard Grandmother say "women like us."

Grandmother freezes.

Ayan freezes.

GRANDMOTHER You think I don't know pain?
You think she didn't hurt?
You think self-combing is just making your hair look nice?
She didn't have to marry, but she also couldn't turn back.
Her family didn't accept her as a daughter. The ancestral hall didn't accept her as a proper ancestor.
When she was sick, only Axin stayed beside her.
In those years of war and chaos, when Axin died, she couldn't even cry too loudly.
She had to hide, because if she cried, people would ask: What exactly are you two?

Ayan becomes quiet.

Grandmother also realizes she has said too much and turns away.

The sound of the fan.

Cicadas.

Ayan says softly.

Lights rise as they return to reality.

AYAN Then what were they?

Grandmother does not answer.

Ayan continues asking.

AYAN Grandma, what do you think they were? Tell me.

Grandmother faces away from her. Her voice is very low.

GRANDMOTHER In life, how can everything be explained so clearly? It can only be counted as something fate owed them.

Ayan shakes her head.

AYAN No.
They were people who chose each other. They were truly together.

Grandmother's shoulders move slightly.

Ayan looks at her.

AYAN So you're not afraid that I'll choose wrong.
You're afraid I'll become her. You're afraid fate will do that to me too...

Grandmother does not answer.

Grandmother finally turns around.

GRANDMOTHER But life is just like this.
I have lived to this age. I know how much women suffer after they refuse to obey.
She didn't marry, and people said that after death, women like her would become lonely ghosts with no one to worship them.
You like girls, and people will curse you too.
You think just because the era has changed, mouths can no longer hurt people? Rumors can kill...

Ayan's eyes redden, but her voice remains hard.

AYAN They can.
But you can't tie me up first just because knives can cut people.

The phone rings.

Both of them are startled.

Ayan looks at the screen.

AYAN My mom.

She answers the call.

MOTHER'S VOICE Ayan, we came back early. Your dad is driving over to pick you up now. Pack up. He'll be there in half an hour.
AYAN I'm leaving today?
MOTHER'S VOICE Yes. The ten days are up. It's time to come home.

Ayan is silent.

MOTHER'S VOICE Have you been listening to your grandmother these days?

Ayan looks at Grandmother.

Grandmother lowers her head and tidies the lychee shells, as if she has not heard.

AYAN Mom, Grandma has been very good to me. I didn't make her angry.

Grandmother's hand pauses.

MOTHER'S VOICE That's good. Your grandmother is old. Don't keep upsetting her.
AYAN Mm.

She takes the phone aside.

MOTHER'S VOICE Also, about that friend of yours, we'll talk when you get home.

Ayan grips the phone tightly.

AYAN Mom.
She has a name.
AYAN Her name is...

The call ends.

The room is quiet.

The cicadas grow louder.

Grandmother pushes the peeled lychees toward Ayan.

GRANDMOTHER Eat them on the road.
AYAN They'll dirty the car.
GRANDMOTHER Then eat them now.

Ayan picks up a lychee but does not eat it.

She looks at Grandmother.

AYAN Grandma, is there anything else you want to say to me?
GRANDMOTHER What do you want me to say?

Ayan thinks for a moment.

AYAN Grandma, thank you. I will keep the memories here secret forever.

Grandmother nods.

Ayan continues packing.

She takes out the red socks, the amulet, and the paper figure one by one, placing them back on the table. Finally, she picks up the dress.

AYAN This, I'm not taking.

Grandmother looks at the dress.

GRANDMOTHER Then don't take it.

Ayan folds the dress neatly and puts it back on the chair.

AYAN But don't make anyone else wear it either.

Grandmother does not answer.

Ayan zips up the suitcase.

The sound of the zipper is clear.

She stands and looks at the auntie's photograph projected in the ancestral hall behind her.

As Grandmother busies herself, the lights dim, and the photograph appears again.

AYAN Grandma, "Auntie of the Chen Family" should be changed. She deserves to have her own name.
AYAN Grandma, so do you.

Grandmother is silent.

The cicadas grow louder.

The car arrives.

She goes into the room to get something.

GRANDMOTHER Ayan, this photo album records many stories about self-combed women. I hope that one day you can let more people know this story. Just like you said, women like us are worthy.

She lowers her head and looks at the genealogy book, then at the pen in her hand.

The sound of the cicadas covers everything.

The projected photograph of the auntie slowly brightens.

Final image:

Grandmother stands in the middle of the ancestral hall.

The genealogy book lies open.

The pen hovers above the page.

The cicadas outside the window grow louder and louder.

Ayan has already left.

Awan remains in the photograph.

Blackout.

End of play.